

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 26, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Dem leaders troubled by mail-in ballot ruling

Durbin calls Trump’s order an effort to ‘chip away’ at right to vote

By Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois’ Democratic leaders expressed trepidation Tuesday after the U.S. Supreme Court allowed the Trump administration to proceed with plans that could severely limit mail-in voting, raising warnings that it could create chaos for the Nov. 3 general election.

With the first day to vote by mail in Illinois less than a month away on Sept. 24, Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker called the ruling “deeply troubling,” while U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin, the No. 2 Democrat in the Senate, said President Donald Trump’s executive order was another attempt by the president to “chip away at that fundamental right” to vote.

At issue was Monday’s ruling in which the nation’s highest court lifted, at least temporarily, a lower court’s stay of the executive order Trump issued earlier this year.

The order directs the Department of Homeland Security to create a list of adult U.S. citizens in each state and requires states to give the U.S. Postal Service a list of voters to whom they intend to send mail-in ballots. It also prevents the USPS from mailing ballots to people not on the agency list of “enrolled” voters. Another provision requires the U.S. attorney general to “prioritize” the investigation and prosecution of state and local officials who issue ballots to ineligible voters.

A separate federal court ruling, which the Supreme Court did not address, still prohibits the postal service from carrying out its part of the executive order. But the administration filed a motion late Monday asking that the second hold be lifted

See **VOTING** on Page A9

IN NATION & WORLD: Supreme Court’s mail-in ballot ruling may inject “chaos” into voting. **Page B5**



Workers perform maintenance on CTA Blue Line tracks near South Pulaski Road shortly after midnight on Sunday in Chicago.
ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Blue Line slow zones frustrate commuters

On Forest Park branch, trains travel on 70-year-old tracks. Fixes could be coming — but slowly

By Talia Soglin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A commuter boarding a Loop-bound Blue Line train in Forest Park during morning rush hour back in 2022 could expect to arrive downtown at Clark and Lake Station in 35 minutes. Now, the same trip takes five or six minutes longer.

The trip home takes even more extra time, to the tune of nine to 10 minutes longer than it did in 2022, according to the CTA’s published schedule.

The culprit?

Slow zones, or sections of the CTA’s aging track where trains must slow to a crawl. On the Forest Park branch of the Blue Line, which carries riders through Chicago’s West Side to suburban Oak Park and Forest Park, slow zones now comprise more than 84% of the track, up from 20% a decade ago.

That’s much higher than the O’Hare branch of the Blue Line, which carries riders through the city’s Northwest Side to the airport, and where just under 15% of the branch is classified as a slow zone.

Systemwide, 19% of all CTA track fell into a slow zone in July. And even on the Brown Line — which has been known to prompt rider complaints of its own when it comes to speed — slow zones made up just 21% of the line.

On the Blue Line’s Forest Park branch, trains travel on tracks that are nearly 70 years old, and that makes for time-consuming commutes.

“It’s slower than just about anything,” said Keith Long, a hospital employee waiting for a Forest Park-bound train at the Illinois Medical District station

during an afternoon rush hour last month. On the O’Hare branch of the line, Long said, “it feels like the trains actually know how to go.”

“I have no desire to take this on a regular basis,” said Robert Rodgers as he sat aboard a Forest Park-bound train crawling west. Rodgers, of Hyde Park, was headed to visit a friend in the western suburbs. Still, he acknowledged, he’d taken the train because it was “less of a headache than driving.”

The CTA says a full replace-

See **BLUE** on Page A4

DOLLY PARTON 1946-2026



Dolly Parton performs at the Chicago Theatre on May 8, 2008. **ABEL URIBE/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Why I loved Parton and her Dollywood



Chris Jones

In the middle of Dollywood — a theme park in the Smoky Mountains that I have visited 50 times or more — there’s a replica of the one-bedroom house in which Dolly Parton grew up in Sevier County, Tennessee, as one of 12 children.

IN CHICAGOLAND: Tributes to the beloved singer poured in from all over the area. **Page A2**

It’s not the actual house, although some visitors tend to think so. But it’s the same size. And if you stand and peer through the window alongside the moms, dads and kids in strollers, as I often have, you hear a symphony of people articulating their new understanding of just how far this great American came.

Humble beginnings are a cliché. Parton, though, escaped a space barely big enough for 14 people to turn around. Humble does not do it justice, but palpably, she grew up surrounded by love.

She conquered country music, then Hollywood. Then she became an entrepreneur with her own theme park in Pigeon Forge. Just recently, she’d moved into Dolly’s travel stops, taking on the Buc-ee’s chain with her

See **PARTON** on Page A2

Coal ash by Vermilion River raises alarms

Many worry about heavy rains and delays in erosion report

By Christiana Freitag
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

For more than 70 years, Mike Camp has never lived more than 2 miles from the Vermilion River.

Growing up on his family’s dairy and crop farms in Vermilion County in east-central Illinois, Camp spent his childhood and adult life swimming, fishing and canoeing along the meandering bends of the river’s Middle Fork.

“We’ve floated the river our whole lives,” Camp said.

He and his wife, Kristin, currently live less than a mile and a half from the river in Collison. They have spent more than a decade fighting to protect it from over 3 million cubic yards of toxic coal ash stored on the Middle Fork’s floodplain, a particularly

vulnerable location along Illinois’ only national scenic river.

A few miles downstream, a coal-fired power plant operated for more than 50 years before being retired in 2011. Camp said he first became concerned when he was canoeing and saw ash deposits seeping into the river, leaving rainbow-colored sheens along the bank.

Vistra Corp. acquired Dynegy Midwest Generation, the owner of the retired plant, in 2018. Dynegy submitted a plan to the Illinois Environmental Protection Agency to permanently close the coal ash ponds more than four years ago.

That plan has yet to be approved. In the meantime, residents and environmentalists are worried about the company’s response as severe storms increase erosion and the threat of the river overflowing into the coal ash ponds.

Heavy rains pushed the Middle

See **RIVER** on Page A5

FOOD & HEALTH Lincoln Park dining guide

There is much to do in Lincoln Park and ample ways the neighborhood help sustain those who wish to explore it, thanks to a vibrant collection of restaurants, cafes and bakeries.



TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/TRIBUNE

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 84 L: 65
THU. H: 82 L: 63
FRI. H: 80 L: 64
Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A9
Arts & Living B8
Comics B12-B13
Crossword B13
Editorials A6
Horoscope B12
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A9
Television B11

179th year No. 238
© Chicago Tribune

